

What to do before writing the recommendation letter

- 1) Understand what the recommendation letter should talk about. Yes, the recommendation letter is used to talk about your strengths and why you are a good fit for the university program, but note that each recommendation has a specific purpose.
The **teacher recommendations** are supposed to talk about your involvement in class and in a subject/discipline. The **counselor's recommendation** talks about your involvement generally (clubs, leadership, etc).
- 2) In the recommendation, you will need to talk about your **strengths and character traits**. It is wise to write down three or four character traits you would want to illustrate in the letter, e.g. altruism/being selfless, meticulousness/focusing on details, brilliance/being exceptionally intelligent, etc. Ensure that the character traits you mention in each letter are different to avoid repeating yourself.
- 3) As you choose which traits you are going to talk about, also think about the illustration you are going to give to support it. This is actually the most important. Here you need to circle back to what you were taught in regard to **“showing instead of telling”**.

Best practices for writing a recommendation letter

- 1) Use formal language. You can use Grammarly to assist you on this. When setting the standards of your writing, set the language of delivery as formal.
- 2) Use a formal font like Arial, Times New Roman, Cambria and Garamond. I highly recommend Times New Roman because it's used in US schools for writing assignments. (Very, very true) Use font size 12, with no italics, and font color is Black. The only place you can use a heavier font is in the reference. Use the BOLD feature for this.
- 3) Keep your salutation (Dear Admissions Committee) and valediction (Yours sincerely, Katie McAllister) to the left of the page, very, very important, please note.
- 4) Remember to present yourself in the best light. If you want to talk about a weakness, ensure you also explain how you overcame the weakness. For instance, failing an exam, ensure you talk about how you improved.

Here is an example of a teacher recommendation letter. I have added annotations for guidance.

Dear Admissions Committee, OR To The Admissions Office,

Address this letter generally to the admissions committee or office. Do not specify to a particular admissions officer because you're not sure he/she is the one evaluating your application. Also, do not address it to a specific school's admissions office e.g. Dear Penn Admissions Office, Dear MIT Admissions Office, etc. Remember that there is a possibility you might get to do RD

applications and apply to so many schools. So in order for the recs to be applicable to all schools, just be general and say Dear Admissions Office, without any specifications.

RE: RECOMMENDATION LETTER FOR EDITH WAYUA NGUNDI, COMMON APP ID: 20612017

All of you remember writing official letters in high school English Paper 1 (turns out it was going to be useful after all, hehe). Ensure you write the reference. Include your full name and your common app ID (your mentors can assist you with this)

Nowadays, whenever someone asks what I look for in a student, Edith's name is one of the few which resurfaces from the depths of many. Edith was a philomath when it came to Complex Systems class, and this never failed to show in our interactions in the classroom. (Introduce your relationship with the applicant. How do you know each other?) From her outstanding analytical skills, creative edge, personalized approach to learning, and one for the jokes as well, she was a beautiful mind to cultivate. (Briefly talk about the applicant so that we can understand why you were willing to draft a recommendation for him/her) and I am more than grateful to have had this privilege.

Where most of the other students would merely scratch the surface of a concept in class, Edith was unafraid to dig deep. (First character trait: INTELLECTUAL THINKER. Notice how this is illustrated instead of just mentioning plainly "Edith is an intellectual thinker". I mean you can do this, but please do not just stop there. Ensure that you illustrate how Edith is an intellectual thinker) I got to know her from the meaningful answers she would offer me. Edith was not shallow when discussing topics and would offer broader perspectives to her fellow students. They would always look forward to her input in class discussions and jot down notes every time she spoke, ready to take something to add to their work. (the illustration continues) When we started on the unit Negotiation and Mediation, her group assignment stood out as objective and insightful. (ensure that you at least give one specific example to show what a memorable student you were) In her section, she drew up both positive and negative reviews of current methods, offering novel perspectives to improve their shortcomings. I still draw new conclusions from her work. From this ever-growing trait, she will continue to thrive on campus and take advantage of your resources to draw definitive work.

Out-of-the-box adjustments were the highlight of Edith's learning. She was a powerful tool right from the first day of my SS51 class, and she filled these shoes, grew in them, and eventually broke into a run. Most students restated vital points from the class readings. Edith broke the mold by testing how practical they were in the real world. (Second character trait: PRACTICAL THINKER, followed by an illustration) Above it all, she would question how effective the principles were in addressing problems on different levels in society and in different contexts. Such was the case during class role-playing exercises, where Edith put what she learned to the

test. She would embody the roles assigned to her, addressing the real world's complexities and how the lessons could be applicable with a little tweak here and there.

Preferring to take contrarian perspectives, (Third character trait: CONTRARIAN, followed by an illustration) she came up with very creative ideas, borrowing inspiration from interesting places and taking note of nuances in readings. During the class analysis of the 1996 Everest Disaster, she illuminated what she thought happened during the expedition. While most students agreed that disharmony in the expedition teams led to the members' separation and eventual fatality, Edith believed that motivation was a more significant contributor. She explained that some of the hikers were wealthy professionals and could therefore afford another hike. However, others were not well-off and had been saving up for the expedition. Edith felt that the latter group had a greater need to finish the hike, no matter how low the temperatures got, hence the disaster. She alluded to how rare items are considered more valuable, explaining her concept so beautifully to the class. Edith motivated her colleagues to think outside the box, challenging each other with novel perspectives. I enjoyed seeing my students learning from each other and how lively the classes became. I'm sure Edith is eager to recover her class presence at your university.

Adapting to the college-level Social Sciences curriculum seemed almost immediate for Edith. (Fourth character trait: ADAPTIVE, FLEXIBLE, CREATIVE, followed by an illustration) She tailored her classwork to suit her understanding. Such was the mindset behind drawing small charts representing the Minerva SS50 and SS51 HCs or making a joke out of a concept she needed to remember. She would be contextual about everything, and she sought to make her work enjoyable and easily understood. This consistently grew into something impressive that she brought to her class breakout groups. She had a more straightforward way of understanding difficult concepts, presenting her ideas in her own words instead of rigid work. Her breakout group discussions were engaging, and I would often allow them to share what they discussed when the whole class converges. I must admit that I miss that class because there was a notable improvement in study interest and class material.

From her way with words to her avocado shirt that reads 'Avo Nice Day', Edith was a lover of light-hearted moments as well. (Fifth character trait: HUMOROUS, followed by an illustration. Note that this is the last paragraph and you don't need to talk about a character trait here. I just did this as a parting shot- being humorous wasn't as important as the other traits for me. It could be important to you, and if it is, ensure you give it as much space as possible, just like I did for the rest) From our conversations and class discussions, she knew when to stretch a good argument humorously while also holding tact. I am confident that Edith will look to bloom wherever she is planted and demonstrate the need to profit the institution as well. You have my utmost assurance on that. She holds a lot of promise, which I know you will all collectively realize. I will miss her, though. (This part can also serve as a good last paragraph, just the way it

is. Ensure that you talk about how you believe that the applicant will be an invaluable addition to the college community)

(SIGNATURE)

Katie McAllister, Ph.D.,

Associate Professor of Social Sciences

Minerva Schools at KGI

(Name of the recommender; the position (Biology Teacher, Mathematics Teacher, etc) and the school. Ensure that you leave ample space for the signature- this should be after the last paragraph. The school stamp can come after the valediction)

(SCHOOL STAMP)